The No-Surprises Protocol

Bad news doesn't get better with age. And neither does good news.

From ***AI Will Scale Good Leadership and Bad Leadership:*** *The CHRO's Method for Redesigning Work Before AI Scales What's Broken* by Liz Corey · Toolbox No. 13

The communication discipline for the entire transformation, installable this month. Leaders know roles are changing. They know redesigns are coming. When they say nothing for months because the message is hard, employees read the silence perfectly and fill it with the worst version.

THE PROTOCOL

1 The three-part cadence, every month, from the top

Here's what we know. Here's what we don't know yet. Here's when you'll hear more. Silence is a message; stop sending it.

2 The hard-news rule

The moment a redesign decision is firm enough to plan around, it's firm enough to share with the people it affects. Bad news doesn't get better with age.

3 The good-news ledger

Every reinvestment win, role upgrade, and internal move gets shared within the week it happens, with names when the people agree. Good news doesn't get better with age either.

4 The ambiguity inventory

List the policies, standards, and decisions your AI effort will force into single versions. For each, name who currently benefits from the fog, and whether the fog is protecting power or protecting a customer. That list is your real stakeholder map. It lives in the companion workbook, and it is not for publishing.

The question before adoption. Four questions, in this order: Should we change? What should change? How should we implement it? Will people adopt it? The famous frameworks only start carrying real weight at question three. AI enablement doesn't begin with adoption. It begins upstream.

The discipline, in four lines. Tell people what you know when you know it. Tell them what you don't know yet, and when you will. Never let a rumor be more current than you are. Spend the good news the day you earn it.

The payoff. Trust becomes something you're visibly earning instead of quietly spending, and resistance stops surprising you because you mapped its interests in advance.

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RUN THE CADENCE

The three-part message, drafted

Get your CEO to deliver this about AI and jobs at your company, this month, before any more rollouts. Draft it yourself if you have to.

Messenger: **Date:** **Audience:**

Here's what we know.

Here's what we don't know yet.

Here's when you'll hear more.

The hard-news check

Is this decision firm enough to plan around? ☐ Yes ☐ No If yes, it is firm enough to share.

Who it affects: **Who tells them:** **By when:**

The good-news ledger within the week it happens

THE WIN (REINVESTMENT, ROLE UPGRADE, INTERNAL MOVE)	NAMES, WITH PERMISSION	SHARED BY	SHARED ON

Communication is a designed workstream: ☐ Audiences mapped ☐ Messengers chosen ☐ Sequence planned ☐ Timing owned

A dashboard can't deliver courage. AI can surface the patterns, draft the documentation, and help a manager prepare for the hardest conversation of their quarter. None of it changes the obligation. Leadership still has to walk into the room and tell the truth.

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